had usually brought me back into the United side after games missed because of injury. I felt I was part of his best eleven. I didn't find out otherwise until the day of the game. We were having our pre-match meal. The manager came and sat next to me:

'I'm starting with Ole. I can't change the team.'

I couldn't help but be disappointed, but I didn't feel like an argument over it. I wasn't happy but the manager was doing what he thought was best. My job was to sit on the substitute's bench and be ready.

Because of the speculation about my future, people pointed to the boss leaving me out as proof things weren't right between us. As far as I was concerned, though, I was a United player, and me not playing against Arsenal wasn't going to change that. It was a strange night: not much of a game when you compared it to the stuff that had been played in Madrid, by both sides, the previous week. But it had all the tension and drama anybody could have asked for. Ruud scored. Thierry Henry scored twice and then Giggsy equalized. At the end, the gaffer went running onto the field, punching the air. He's always loved beating them and I think he knew the 2–2 was just what we needed. I remember being in the tunnel afterwards. Gossip gets round players as well and the rumors hadn't really stopped since the last time we'd played Arsenal, back in February up at Old Trafford. I remember Thierry Henry walking past me and raising an eyebrow:

'What's the matter? Why weren't you playing?'

Then he laughed:

'You can come and play for us if you like.'

I laughed too.

The boss was really pleased with what had happened. I actually remember him saying, particularly, how well he thought Ole Gunnar Solskjaer had played. Even so, come the Saturday and home to Blackburn, Ole was on the bench and I started a game for the first time since we'd been beaten in Madrid. Blackburn were on a really good run and played well but we won 3–1. I was happy to be back in the team and happy with how I played. But something still didn't feel right. The obvious picture was that I was fit again and the manager had wanted to give me a game before the second leg against Real the following Wednesday. Everybody assumed I'd be playing in United's biggest match of the season. Except me. Over the weekend I became more